are found in such areas, much of which are cropped by shifting cultivation, in which the cyclical use of land provides periodic regeneration of plant nutrients.

Statement 2: INCORRECT—In northwest China, some areas are covered by a thin layer of wind-blown material dating from the retreat of the ice sheet during the most recent Ice Age. This material is known by the term loess, and adds considerably to the natural fertility of the soil and thus to the agricultural productivity of the area.

Statement 3: INCORRECT—Surveying the overall picture of soil distribution in Asia, it can be concluded that for its size, much of the continent offers limited opportunities for productive agricultural land. No more than 20% of the land surface is estimated to contain soils suitable for agriculture and a good quarter of this percentage contains soils of marginal value.

70. China has chiefly high-grade coal reserves. Every province has at least one coalfield, but the largest reserves are in Shanxi and Shaanxi in the Ordos River basin in the north.

Siberia produces more natural gas than Southwest Asia and is a significant oil producer as well. The flanks of the Ural Mountains have a number of large oil fields and small gas fields.

Azerbaijan and the former Soviet republics of Central Asia also possess large deposits of oil and natural gas. Much of this is centred in the Caspian basin, particularly in areas claimed by Azerbaijan. The capital, Baku, has become a new world centre for oil exploration.

Although China formerly was regarded as deficient in iron ores, huge quantities of varying grades of ores have been discovered that are widely distributed and often located close to coal supplies. Regional centres of ore mining, smelting, and fabrication are located at Anshan in Liaoning province; near Beijing; in southern Anhui, west of Shanghai; in central China, east of Wuhan; in southern Inner Mongolia, north of Baotou; in central western Gansu; and on Hainan Island, off the southern coast. Large iron ore deposits also occur near Chongqing. Iron ore in small local volumes is widely located in Guizhou and Yunnan in the